

Password Reset and Account Access Guide

Northgate Group — IT Service Desk Manual | Version 3.1 | Effective 1 January 2026 | Owner: IT Operations

1. Scope

This guide covers self-service password reset, the password standard, account lockout and unlock, multi-factor authentication device changes, and the escalation route to an IT administrator when self-service is not available.

2. Self-Service Password Reset

Most password problems are resolved by the employee in a few minutes without a ticket. Self-service reset is available at any time, including outside service desk hours.

- Step one: open the account self-service portal from the sign-in page and select the reset option.
- Step two: enter the company email address and complete the verification prompt on the enrolled authentication device.
- Step three: choose a new password that meets the standard set out below.
- Step four: sign out of all devices and sign in again with the new password, starting with the laptop.
- Step five: if working remotely, reconnect the VPN before opening any internal application, because the new password is required to re-establish the tunnel.

A remote worker who changes a password while away from the office should stay connected to the VPN throughout the change where possible. Changing a password with the VPN disconnected can leave the cached credential on the laptop out of step with the account, which presents at the next sign-in as a rejected password even though the new password is correct.

3. Password Standard

- Minimum 16 characters; a passphrase of several unrelated words is preferred to a short complex string.
- The previous 10 passwords cannot be reused, and a password cannot be changed more than once in 24 hours without service desk involvement.
- The password must not contain the employee's name, the company name or the month.
- Passwords expire after 180 days; a reminder is sent 14 days before expiry.
- Passwords must never be shared, emailed, entered into a ticket comment or stored in a document.

4. Account Lockout

An account locks after five consecutive failed sign-in attempts. A locked account unlocks automatically after 30 minutes. Waiting for the automatic unlock is usually faster than raising a ticket.

Repeated lockouts within a short period are almost always caused by a stale password cached somewhere other than the laptop, most often on a mobile device mail profile or on a second machine left signed in. Check and update every device before raising a ticket, and state in the ticket which devices have been checked.

5. Multi-Factor Authentication Device Changes

An employee replacing a phone must enrol the new device before the old one is wiped or returned. Enrolment is completed in the account self-service portal while still signed in on the old device.

If the enrolled device has been lost, stolen or wiped before re-enrolment, self-service is no longer available and the account must be recovered by an IT administrator. Report a lost or stolen authentication device immediately, because it also requires the associated sessions to be revoked.

6. Escalation to an IT Administrator

Raise an IT ticket with the request type Software Issue where self-service cannot be used. Verification is required before any manual reset: the service desk confirms identity by a video call with the company identity card visible, or in person at the IT desk. A password will never be reset on the basis of an email or chat request alone.

- No access to the enrolled authentication device and no alternative method enrolled.
- Account disabled rather than locked, which usually follows a security alert.
- Repeated lockout that continues after every device has been checked.
- Suspected compromise of the account, which is always treated as high priority.

7. Shared and Service Accounts

Shared accounts are not issued to individuals. Where a team needs common access, a group is applied to each individual account instead. Service accounts used by an application are owned by a named team, are excluded from interactive sign-in and have their credentials rotated every 90 days by IT Operations.

8. Phishing and Suspected Compromise

IT Operations will never ask for a password by email, chat or telephone. Any message requesting a password, or a sign-in prompt that appears unexpectedly, should be reported using the report message function in the mail client.

An employee who believes a password has been disclosed should change it immediately through self-service and then raise a high priority ticket. Do not wait for the ticket to be picked up before changing the password, and do not include the disclosed password in the ticket.